THE PRICE OF PLAY

Psychology, Business Ethics and the Changing Value of Digital Gaming (2013–2026)

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ABSTRACT

What does a player purchase when buying a game: an experience, a work of art, a sequence of challenges, or an invitation to recurring payment? This conceptual working paper re-examines the author's unfinished 2013 manuscript Świat oczami gracza through contemporary psychological and business-ethical debates. It argues that profitability and monetisation are not inherently unethical, but game systems become ethically questionable when they obscure costs, manufacture pressure, weaken meaningful player choice or alter the fundamental product proposition. Research on self-determination, freemium purchases and loot boxes is discussed alongside the historical case of Diablo III's discontinued auction houses. The paper also examines creative autonomy under commercial management, using Fallout 2 as an illustrative rather than definitive example. It proposes a preliminary Player-Centred Ethical Game Design framework and a Creative Integrity Agreement as practical subjects for future investigation. These are normative proposals, not validated scientific instruments. Counterarguments concerning accessibility, sustainable financing, differences among players and limitations of the evidence are explicitly considered.

Keywords: *digital gaming; psychological autonomy; intrinsic motivation; business ethics; microtransactions; player trust; dark patterns; corporate responsibility; creative autonomy; loot boxes; game design.*

PUBLICATION NOTE

The author's Polish manuscript Świat oczami gracza, held in the 2013 archive, was unfinished and was not a documented empirical study (Kołodziej, 2013). This paper is a contemporary 2026 reconstruction incorporating later evidence. It is a conceptual scholarly essay, not a systematic review or original empirical investigation. The author's own interpretations are distinguished from scientific findings.

1. THE PLAYER AND THE PRODUCT

Imagine a child attempting a difficult jump in an old platform game. One mistake uses a precious life. Another attempt follows. Slowly the timing becomes familiar. The player finally reaches the next stage. The reward is not simply the screen announcing success. It is the experience of having learned.

Now consider another fictional scene. A player intends to leave a contemporary online game, but a notification warns that the daily reward will disappear. The player is tired, and nothing interesting remains to be explored. Nevertheless, the prospect of losing something makes another session seem obligatory.

These are hypothetical illustrations, not observations or research data. They invite a distinction between wanting to play and feeling compelled to keep participating. In 2013, the author's concern was to understand the gamer's world rather than judge it solely by screen time. By 2026 an additional question had emerged: how do the institutions designing that world shape the psychological conditions of participation?

A video game is simultaneously entertainment, a cultural product, a system of rules, often a social environment, and sometimes an ongoing commercial service. Its value may lie in narrative, discovery, cooperation, achievement or relaxation. A profitable design can serve these values. Yet the source of revenue is not neutral when it changes how the game rewards actions and influences decisions.

This paper does not claim that the past was universally better. Nor does it argue that every game should demand severe effort. It asks what happens when monetisation begins to determine experiences that previously arose mainly from playing.

2. THE EVOLUTION OF GAME MONETISATION

There was never a pristine age entirely free of commercial incentives. Arcade machines charged for attempts. Subscription games charged for continuing access. Boxed games sometimes received expansion packs, and online services required maintenance. However, the variety and integration of contemporary purchasing mechanisms have changed the relationship between an initial payment and the resulting experience.

The horse armour pack for The Elder Scrolls IV: Oblivion, released in April 2006, cost 200 Microsoft Points (approximately US$2.50) on Xbox 360 and provoked contemporary debate over the value of a small paid add-on (Surette, 2006). It was not the first microtransaction. Its historical significance here is as a visible example of consumers questioning the relationship between additional payment and the content delivered.

Contemporary categories must be examined separately. A major story expansion may contain genuinely new creative work. A fixed-price cosmetic item may enable personal expression. A pay-to-convenience item changes the relationship between progress and time. A randomised purchase introduces uncertainty about what a payment will deliver. A battle pass may reward ongoing participation, but can also create pressure to keep playing to avoid wasting a previous purchase.

A free-to-play title may rely on optional sales for financial survival. A subscription may support continuous server provision. None of these models is necessarily exploitative simply because payment is recurring. The ethical question is how the system works and what choices it leaves to consumers.

Business research complicates simplistic judgments. Hamari, Hanner and Koivisto (2017) found that service quality in free-to-play environments was associated with continued usage without straightforwardly explaining premium purchases. Their later study (2020) examined perceived value and the complex relationship between enjoyment, continued use and spending. Such findings suggest that what makes a product attractive and what encourages additional expenditure are not identical.

This difference creates both opportunities and risks. A company may earn revenue by offering desirable additions. It may also create inconvenience and sell its removal. To analyse ethics seriously, the two situations must not be treated as equivalent.

3. MOTIVATION, COMPETENCE AND THE MEANING OF ACHIEVEMENT

Why does overcoming a difficult opponent feel satisfying? Often the answer is not simply that a reward appears. A person recognises an improvement in skill, judgment or understanding.

Self-determination theory identifies autonomy, competence and relatedness as central psychological needs (Ryan and Deci, 2000). In studies of video game motivation, Ryan, Rigby and Przybylski (2006) associated perceived autonomy and competence with enjoyment and other aspects of gameplay. This research supports examining games as environments in which agency and mastery matter.

The original Super Mario Bros. provides a familiar illustration: repeated attempts, limited lives and learnable patterns. Diablo II presents another kind of challenge through item progression and, in many modes, consequences after character death. More demanding action games associated with the Soulslike tradition can likewise make preparation and learning central to satisfaction.

Yet severe difficulty is not automatically educational or enjoyable. Accessibility settings, frequent checkpoints and forgiving failure can allow people with different abilities, time constraints and preferences to experience a work. A relaxing game may offer genuine psychological value without imposing stressful challenges. This paper therefore rejects any simple equation between difficulty and quality.

The relevant concept is the integrity of effort and reward. Consider two identical in-game achievements: one earned by mastering a demanding encounter, the other immediately purchased. Their visual appearance may be the same, but their significance to a particular player may differ. For some, the achievement represents effort and competence; for others, the item is primarily a way to customise a character.

A studio that encourages players to value mastery but then sells a way to bypass mastery may produce a contradiction in its own design. The consequence is not necessarily clinical harm. It may instead be a loss of perceived meaning, fairness or motivation for some users. Which users, in which games and under which circumstances remain empirical questions.

The author also raises a developmental hypothesis. Frequent experiences in which payment substitutes for effort could affect how some young people interpret delayed gratification. But the available discussion does not establish that microtransactions cause lower perseverance, impaired learning or poor functioning in adult life. Such claims would require rigorous longitudinal evidence and attention to family, education, personality and socioeconomic circumstances.

4. ENGAGEMENT VERSUS MANIPULATIVE PRESSURE

Games necessarily motivate behaviour. Stories create curiosity. Challenges encourage repetition. Friendships invite players back. The fact that someone wishes to continue playing is not evidence of manipulation.

The crucial difference lies in the design of choice. A player may return because participation is enjoyable, or because a system deliberately makes absence feel costly. Daily login streaks, artificial scarcity, time-limited purchases and season pass schedules can shift the focus of a session away from discovery toward preventing a loss.

Not every timed event is manipulative. Seasonal experiences may build community and shared excitement. The ethical concern becomes stronger where an interface uses avoidable urgency, confusing currencies or pressure to spend in ways unrelated to a game's genuine creative purpose.

Chance-based purchases warrant distinct attention. Zendle and Cairns (2018) reported a relationship between loot-box spending and problem gambling in a large survey. The authors cautioned that their results did not establish causation. People with existing gambling difficulties may be more likely to purchase loot boxes, or some purchase designs may contribute to problems; the cross-sectional association cannot settle which interpretation is correct.

King and Delfabbro (2018) discussed potentially predatory schemes in which the long-term cost remains unclear until players are already committed financially or psychologically. King and Delfabbro (2019) subsequently outlined possible social-responsibility measures. This literature provides reason to evaluate concealed costs and probabilistic purchases without claiming that every user becomes addicted.

The phrase 'dopamine hit' is often used to explain repeated short gaming sessions. It is scientifically imprecise when treated as a complete account of enjoyment or addiction. This paper focuses instead on observable design characteristics: the schedule of rewards, scarcity cues, perceived pressure, payment uncertainty and the degree of real choice.

The author's ethical judgment applies to every consumer. Children may require additional safeguards, but manipulation does not become acceptable because an adult is legally entitled to purchase the product. Honesty and respect for autonomy are not age-specific privileges.

5. DIABLO III: WHEN COMMERCE CHANGES THE GAME

The history of Diablo III provides a documented example in which commercial functionality and the intended play experience came into conflict. The game introduced auction houses permitting transactions in virtual gold and real money. In September 2013 Blizzard stated that, despite advantages for trading, these systems undermined the essential loop of defeating enemies to obtain better equipment. It announced their removal, implemented in March 2014 (Hight, 2013).

This admission is analytically significant. A transaction system may make progression more convenient while weakening the meaning of seeking and earning loot. What matters is not that buying an object is universally immoral. It is that design choices can displace the activity the game originally promised to make rewarding.

The contrast with Diablo II needs care. That earlier game also had item trading and outside markets. Diablo III's history therefore cannot demonstrate that commerce and loot-based games are universally incompatible. It illustrates the narrower proposition that an integrated market can affect the incentive to participate in the core activity, enough that the developer itself chose to remove it.

From this example the author derives a provisional principle: financial systems should not undermine the psychological meaning of the mechanics around which a game is built. If the central pleasure is learning, discovery or mastery, a studio should carefully assess whether purchasable shortcuts diminish that experience for players who engage as intended.

There is a further concern about 'selling the cure'. A company might make progression unnecessarily inconvenient and later charge to remove the inconvenience. Without internal documentation it would be improper to attribute this deliberate intention to a named developer. As an incentive problem, however, it warrants ethical evaluation.

6. THE ETHICS OF TRANSPARENCY AND CONSUMER TRUST

Suppose two studios sell similar games at the same upfront price. One has no additional shop. The other prominently explains before purchase that it offers a permanent cosmetic store. Prices are fixed, purchases are

genuinely optional, the items do not change game balance, and there are no misleading countdowns.

The author's considered view is that the second approach need not be unethical. This is an important refinement. His objection is not to additional revenue itself but to manipulation, inadequate disclosure and unreasonable pressure. A producer may make substantial profits while respecting consumers.

Transparency therefore means more than technically placing information somewhere in terms and conditions. Relevant costs and conditions should be accessible, clear and communicated before the user makes a commitment. The company should not advertise one kind of product while concealing a materially different payment system.

Transparency is necessary but not sufficient. Even a disclosed practice can be designed to exploit a predictable vulnerability. Meaningful choice requires the practical ability to decline purchases without excessive pressure or manufactured loss. The label 'optional' is not a substitute for examining how an interface actually works.

Another concern appears when monetisation changes after purchase. A customer who bought a game and invested considerable time may experience a later addition of aggressive purchases as a breach of trust, especially if the original presentation created a clear expectation of a self-contained experience. Not every update is deceptive, and the legal meaning of misrepresentation varies across jurisdictions. The ethical responsibility nevertheless includes communicating material changes and considering the expectations of existing players.

The separate issue of whether players can continue accessing purchased online games after server shutdowns is reserved for a later publication about digital ownership and preservation. The present argument concerns what firms promise and how they revise the conditions of play.

7. CREATIVE AUTONOMY AND RESPONSIBLE MANAGEMENT

Games are commercial products, but some are also works of art. Their value may depend on distinctive narrative voices, unusual mechanics and experiments that consumers could not have demanded before

encountering them. Innovation cannot be assessed solely by asking audiences which familiar features they already like.

Commercial planning is unavoidable. Studios must fund teams, manage delivery and assess risk. Yet artistic decisions should not always be reduced to projected transactions. When the commercial question dominates every creative choice, a project may gradually reproduce known market formulas rather than allow a genuinely new experience.

The author uses Fallout 2 as an illustrative and contested case. Chris Avellone recalled being assigned particular locations, including New Reno and Vault City, after personnel changes at Interplay; the work was divided among designers under considerable time pressure (London, 2010). A subsequent retrospective based on developers' recollections also described an accelerated production schedule and uneven tone across locations (Dransfield, 2019). The game illustrates how creative latitude can enrich a world while weak coordination and rushed schedules can complicate coherence. It is not evidence that distributed authorship reliably improves game quality or that the management process was exemplary.

A coherent creative director can protect the overall vision while granting meaningful discretion to writers, artists and designers. Whether this arrangement is suitable depends on the team's size, goals and agreed responsibilities. The principle is that autonomy requires structure, not an absence of leadership.

The presence of shareholders does not determine a game's ethical character. Public companies may create original, respectful products; private owners may introduce exploitative designs. Financial pressure may explain decisions without excusing them. Evaluation should focus on implemented systems, not corporate size.

8. A CREATIVE INTEGRITY AGREEMENT

A practical proposal arising from the author's position is a Creative Integrity Agreement established before major production work. This is a conceptual suggestion, not an established industry certification or validated intervention.

Such an agreement would describe the game's intended experience and the scope of artistic autonomy. It would clarify whether the product is sold as a complete game, a subscription service or a free-to-play environment. It would specify permissible monetisation systems, who may approve changes and what kinds of psychological pressure require additional ethical review.

The agreement could also protect decision-making during financial difficulty. Imagine production costs exceeding the budget and management proposing to introduce an optional shop that contradicts the original product proposition. Before altering the experience, responsible leaders could examine financing, release scope, development schedules and price communication. If a significant revision remains necessary, customers' reasonable expectations should be considered openly rather than quietly displaced.

No agreement can guarantee commercial success or artistic excellence. A rigid document could inhibit useful changes. Its value would lie in forcing the organisation to articulate priorities and create accountable procedures for resolving conflicts before crises make decisions hurried and opaque.

9. A PLAYER-CENTRED ETHICAL DESIGN FRAMEWORK

The paper proposes five questions for ethical evaluation rather than a numerical score.

First, transparency: can a prospective player genuinely understand the principal financial conditions before purchase and during participation? Second, autonomy: can a person refuse spending without manufactured pressure or avoidable confusion? Third, reward integrity: are systems for purchasing progress compatible with the activities the product presents as meaningful? Fourth, continuity: are material changes to the product proposition handled honestly and fairly? Fifth, governance: is there an accountable process for reviewing foreseeable psychological and financial consequences?

These questions concern mechanisms and responsibilities. A company's stated intention to make a game more attractive cannot in

itself settle whether a feature is ethical. Equally, a studio's wish to earn money is not evidence of wrongdoing.

The framework should be tested rather than merely asserted. Future studies could investigate consumer comprehension of disclosure formats, differences between fixed-price cosmetic stores and time-limited sales, effects of purchased shortcuts on perceived competence, and whether project-level creative agreements influence employee autonomy or user trust.

10. EDUCATION, POLICY AND THE ROLE OF BUSINESS

Education is a major element of the author's preferred response. Consumers should understand paid randomness, virtual currencies, pressure to log in and the difference between an earned achievement and a purchased shortcut. Parents and schools can contribute to this literacy, but businesses must not shift responsibility for manipulative design entirely onto users.

Public policy already distinguishes some categories of risk. From September 2024, Australian classification rules established minimum M classification for games with paid chance-based items and R18+ for simulated gambling (Australian Classification, 2024). These classifications address defined content risks; they do not certify a game's overall ethics.

A reasonable approach combines understandable disclosure, meaningful consumer education, business self-governance and proportionate safeguards against clearly deceptive or harmful practices. Education is valuable precisely because it respects agency. It is not an excuse for exposing people to unnecessarily manipulative systems.

11. COUNTERARGUMENTS AND LIMITATIONS

This paper is openly normative and selective. It has not compared representative samples of games from 2013 and 2026, measured changes in industry-wide quality or conducted experimental studies of player behaviour. It cannot prove that contemporary games generally reduce perseverance or that all microtransactions harm well-being.

The familiar-versus-new opposition also deserves caution. Older games could be frustrating, repetitive or poorly designed. Modern titles can

provide profound storytelling, creativity, cooperation and learning. Free-to-play games can widen access for people unable to purchase expensive releases. Cosmetic purchases may finance genuine additional development.

Accessibility complicates easy assumptions about effort. A player who selects an easy mode may enjoy the game in precisely the way the creators intended. Ethical analysis should not impose one demanding style of play on everyone. The objection is to engineered financial pressure, not to relaxation.

Likewise, a recurring event can build an enjoyable community without becoming coercive. A visible fixed-price item may be an expression of personal preference. The context, interface, disclosure and impact matter. Research on loot boxes identifies associations with gambling problems, but causation and individual variability remain unresolved in important respects.

Finally, proposed ethical frameworks are not validated measures. The Creative Integrity Agreement and five-question design assessment require empirical testing, operational definitions and independent criticism.

12. CONCLUSION: WHAT IS A GAME WORTH?

A person may play for challenge, discovery, friendship, narrative immersion or simply rest. These reasons differ, and ethical design must leave room for them. What should remain common is the right to clear terms and meaningful choices.

Profit need not undermine art. A successful game may support skilled developers, technical innovation and continued content. The conflict emerges when financial mechanisms obscure the cost of participation, make absence feel like a loss, or replace the meaningful activity that drew players into the game.

The original question in 2013 concerned understanding the person playing. The contemporary question also concerns the organisation constructing the experience. Commercial decisions shape the rules of participation. They can preserve autonomy or weaken it.

Transparency is a starting point. Genuine choice and creative integrity complete the ethical demand. The price of play is not only what appears on a receipt. It is also what the player is asked to surrender in order to continue enjoying the game.

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DECLARATION OF AI-ASSISTED PREPARATION

The paper develops the author's intellectual positions expressed through extended discussion. AI-assisted tools supported research discovery, synthesis, drafting and editing. This is a working manuscript awaiting full author review and final source-to-claim verification.

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